

***Lost, Found,
and Contested***
**The return of the
Memory Wars**
PSYC1003

**SOCIETAL
EDITION**

The Memory Wars Return

Learning Outcomes

- Understand the return of the "memory wars" in society
- Explain current scientific perspectives on false and recovered memories
- Critically evaluate claims about repression and memory recovery
- Compare scientific evidence with ideas presented in *The Body Keeps the Score*
- Critically evaluate *The Tell* as a contemporary recovered-memory narrative
- Consider implications for therapy, research, and legal practice

The Memory Wars in everyday life

Can traumatic memories be unconsciously hidden for years and later recovered accurately?

Pop Culture

Traumatic experiences may be unconsciously repressed and later recovered.

Science

Traumatic experiences are generally remembered, and some recovered memories may be distorted or false.

What Science Tells Us About Memory

Memory should be understood as an active process of reconstruction rather than a permanent recording of experience.

Modern memory research demonstrates that:

- Memory is reconstructive rather than reproductive
- Suggestion can alter autobiographical memories
- Confidence is not a reliable indicator of accuracy
- People can sincerely remember events that never occurred

What Science Tells Us About Memory

The existence of a memory does not necessarily guarantee that the remembered event occurred exactly as recalled.

Research suggests that under certain conditions a substantial minority of participants develop detailed false autobiographical memories.

Repressed Memories: The Scientific Debate

While repressed memories remain influential in popular culture, scientific evidence remains controversial.

several alternative explanations:

- Ordinary forgetting
- Memory retrieval triggered by cues
- Forgetting previous disclosures
- Reinterpretation of past experiences
- Memory reconstruction

There is currently limited empirical support for the idea that traumatic memories are routinely banished from consciousness and later recovered intact.

The Body Keeps the Score

Published in 2014, Bessel van der Kolk's book transformed public conversations about trauma.

Core Ideas

- Trauma affects both mind and body
- Traumatic experiences may be stored in non-verbal forms
- Symptoms can persist long after a traumatic event
- Healing requires more than cognitive understanding

The book has become one of the most influential trauma texts of the past decade.

Any scientific truth in the *Body Keeps the Score*?

Science and The Body Keeps the Score Agree

- V Trauma can have lifelong consequences
- V Trauma can affect emotional regulation
- V Trauma influences physiological stress systems
- V Symptoms may persist long after the original event
- V Trauma survivors require compassionate and effective support

THE EXISTENCE OF TRAUMA IS NOT DISPUTED!

The debate concerns how traumatic memories are encoded, stored, and retrieved.

Any scientific truth in the *Body Keeps the Score*?

Where Science Challenges *The Body Keeps the Score*

- Memories are stored in the brain
- The body does not keep the score as described in the book
- Recovered memories should not automatically be interpreted as evidence of repression
- Recovered memories are not automatically accurate
- Suggestive influences can shape recollections
- False memories can be vivid and emotionally compelling

When a memory emerges after years of apparent absence, multiple explanations must be considered.

What does the public believe?

Public Beliefs About Repression

Recent survey research demonstrates that:

- 93.5% of respondents believed traumatic memories can be repressed
- 93.9% believed such memories can later be recovered
- 77.3% endorsed aspects of the belief that "the body keeps the score"

Belief in repression remains widespread despite continuing scientific controversy. Popular psychology, social media, and bestselling books appear to contribute to these beliefs.

What about “The Tell”

Amy Griffin's memoir *The Tell* describes her experience of recovering memories of childhood sexual abuse. Recovered during MDMA assisted therapy.

Controversies regarding “The Tell”

Scientific

- Recovered memories...
- What about psychedelic assisted therapy?

Legal

- Is it truly her story?
- Psychedelic Industry Shares
- Celebrity Friends Nepotism?

Can recovered memories ever be true?

Verifiability and Corroboration

A recent study examined different forms of delayed abuse memories:

1. Continuous memories
2. Spontaneously recovered memories
3. Memories recovered through active searching

Researchers examined how much externally verifiable information participants reported.

Corroboration remains one of the strongest tools for evaluating historical allegations.

Can recovered memories ever be true?

Key Findings on Verifiability

Continuous Memories

- Contained more verifiable details
- Were more often supported by external evidence

Actively Searched Memories

- Contained fewer verifiable details
- Included more details contradicted by investigations

Important Limitation

These findings do not prove that recovered memories are false. They suggest differences in the degree to which memories can be independently supported.

What does this mean for those claiming recovered memories?

Claims Require Evaluation

Recovered memories should not be:

- Automatically accepted
- Automatically dismissed

Instead, they should be considered alongside:

- Corroborating evidence
- Context
- Alternative explanations
- Clinical presentation

What does the evidence support?

- Trauma is real
- Abuse occurs
- Survivors deserve support
- Memory is reconstructive
 - False memories occur
- Confidence does not equal accuracy
- Corroboration remains important

Believing survivors and evaluating memories critically are not mutually exclusive.

Conclusion

Taken all of this together we can conclude that trauma is a real and significant experience, memory is reconstructive, false memories can emerge, and strong claims about repressed memories remain scientifically contested